

Castles

Medieval castles were built primarily as residences for the wealthy and powerful and their immediate communities, but they were also fortified strongholds and centres of administration. Defences included thick, high walls, secure entry gates, rock foundations and a moat, cylindrical towers, arrow loops and crenellations. To withstand sieges, an integral fresh water supply was vital.

After the fall of the Carolingian empire in the ninth and tenth centuries CE, castles spread across Europe and the Middle East. One of the world's finest surviving medieval castles is the 11th-century Krak des Chevaliers in Syria (opposite). Following William, Duke of Normandy's conquest of England in 1066, he used castles to assert control over the Anglo-Saxon people, who outnumbered the Norman aristocracy. Many were originally built from earth and timber, and were later rebuilt in stone. Between 1066 and 1087, William established 36 castles, including Dover Castle, the Tower of London and Windsor Castle.

